PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · TIPS

When a piece goes nowhere

Every note can be right and the piece still wander. The fix is to see the shape: where the phrases go, what comes back, and where the high point is.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
Every bar sounds the same	**the phrases:** where does each one grow?	p. 148
It feels like a list of notes	**the motif** and its sequences	p. 150
The tune is lost	**the texture:** which line sings?	p. 152
A passage suddenly feels strange	**a new key:** look for the new accidental	p. 154
You lose your place	**the form:** letter the sections	p. 156
It sounds out of style	**the period:** pedal, time and touch	p. 159

Four ways to find the shape

1. **Pencil the phrases**
   Draw a curve over each phrase and mark its high point.
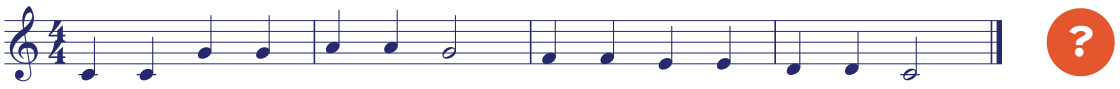
2. **Letter the sections**
   Write A, B, A in the margin. Practise each section on its own.

3. **Sing the tune**
   Sing the top line while you play the rest softly.

4. **Listen to a recording**
   Follow the score and hear the shape before you play it.

EXAMPLE

Where is the high point?



1. **Sing it.**
2. **Which note** is highest?
3. **Grow to it**, then let the phrase fall.

The **As in bar 2**: grow to them, then fall home to C.

THINK OF IT A map does not make the journey, but it stops you getting lost.